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## The expanded UCL format drew scepticism at the start, with concerns over a diluted competitive standard. But after 187 matches, those doubts have faded.

loses the ball, it presses aggressively in midfield. The higher and mid-block players converge centrally, forcing errors and winning back possession.

This strategy has made PSG the top team in ball recoveries this UCL season, with 694 — the third-highest in the past decade, trailing only Atletico Madrid (716 in 2015–16) and Barcelona (728 in 2014–15).

Midfielders Vitinha, Joao Neves, and Fabian Ruiz choke space in central areas, while Kвича Kvaratskhelia and Desire Doue cut off wide overlaps. If the ball still gets through, a backline of four remains. And if that line breaks, Gianluigi Donnarumma — with six clean sheets in the UCL, the second-most this season — stands tall as the final barrier.

When PSG attacks, it commits numbers forward with purpose. Forwards Kvaratskhelia, Doue, and Ousmane Dembele swarm the box, while full-backs Achraf Hakimi and Nuno Mendes surge up the flanks with pace and intent.

This structure, paired with incisive ground passing, limits defensive space and opens up attacking options. The approach has helped PSG move away from dependence on a lone striker — a crucial shift post-Kylian Mbappe.

Notably, the number of goal scorers increased from 15 to 20 in Enrique's first season, with goals now more evenly spread across the squad.

The system mirrors Enrique's treble-winning Barcelona, where Messi, Neymar, and Suarez led the front line while Dani Alves and Jordi Alba offered width and support.

